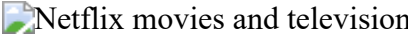


Netflix’s Catalogue Took an International Turn

Netflix’s catalogue grew nearly 25 times from 2015 to 2019, but the biggest change was not how many titles it added.

Sanne DLeema

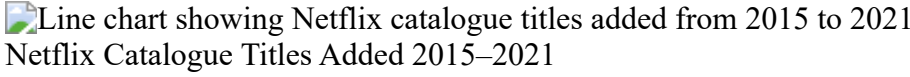


Netflix’s catalogue expanded rapidly during the late 2010s.

Netflix added 24.6 times as many titles in 2019 as compared 2015. Netflix added only 82 titles in thier dataset in 2015, and it climbed to 1,188 till 2017. Later, 461 more titles were included in 2018 and it peaked at 2,016 in 2019. However, the titles fell after 2020 reaching upto 1,498 in 2021.

The catalogue was also uneven in some categories comparing to others. The catalogue, according to dataset contains 6,131 movies compared with 2,676 TV shows, making movies a majority of the content available. This made up about 70% of the titles in the content. This shows that movies were the larger category.

The growth reached the highest in 2019 since 11 years. The number of titles added increased every year during 2015-19, rising from 82 to more than 2,000. After 2019, the number of yearly added titles declined, but the catalogue still received more than 1,400 titles in both 2020 and 2021.



Source: Netflix Movies and TV Shows dataset.

The chart shows how sharply the number of titles added increased during the late 2010s before declining after 2019.

Regardless, the change in Netflix's catalogue was not just about number of titles getting added but also the countries represented in those years also changed.

An Increasingly International Catalogue

According to the data, the titles were classified as international when they included at least one country other than the United States. In 2015, 36.7% of titles added met this consideration. By 2016, the share had risen to 61.2%. IAnd 67.8% in 2017 and peaked at 70.5% in 2018.

The share gradually started to decline, reaching 63.6% in 2019,but remained above 60% in both 2020 and 2021. From 2015 to 2018, the international share increased by 33.8 percentage points, from 36.7% to 70.5%.

Indicating that international titles represented a much larger share of yearly additions in the title than they had at the beginning of the period.



Source: Netflix Movies and TV Shows dataset.

The international share did not continue rising every year. Instead, it reached its highest point in 2018 and then fell somewhat while remaining above 60% through 2021.

The catalogue itself showcased the broadness of thier international presence. India appears in 1,046 titles in the content available, making it the second most represented country after the United States. The United Kingdom appears in 804 titles, followed by Canada with 445 and France with 393. Japan, Spain, South Korea, Germany and Mexico also rank among the countries most frequently represented.

The genre tells a similar narrative. “International Movies” appears 2,752 times among other genres, while “International TV Shows” appears 1,351 times. These labels can overlap with other genre categories because a title can have more than one genre label.

Emerging Korean Content in Netflix

Netflix also identified Korean programmes among the most popular titles in several Asian markets.In 2020, Netflix reported that viewership of Korean content had increased four times or more across Asia compared with 2019. Netflix also identified Korean programmes among the most popular titles in several Asian markets.

These viewership figures are different from the catalogue data. The dataset measures titles and their country information. However, it does not measure how many people watched those titles.

A title can also list several countries, so the international measure used here captures the presence of at least one non-U.S. country rather than the popularity of that title in a particular country.

Altogether, the two sources show two changes happening during the same period. Netflix’s catalogue expanded rapidly, while international titles became a larger share of the titles being added. At the same time, Netflix reported growing viewing of international-language programming in markets across Asia.

Mixed narrative

That does not establish that changing viewer demand caused Netflix to add more international titles. It also does not prove that the catalogue changes were the result of a deliberate international strategy.

What is a clear change in the composition of Netflix’s catalogue. By 2021, more than 60% of the titles added in the dataset met the international-content definition. What started as a rapidly growing catalogue had also become a more geographically diverse one.

About the Data

This analysis uses the Netflix Movies and TV Shows dataset. It examines titles added between 2015 and 2021, comparing the number of titles added each year with the share classified as international.

For this analysis, a title was classified as international when its country information included at least one country other than the United States. Titles with missing country information were excluded from the international-share calculation.

Data source: Netflix Movies and TV Shows dataset.